



APPLICATION NOTE

Interfacing CAN-FD devices with the Binho Pulsar

AN0012

Document information

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Abstract	The Binho Pulsar carries a CAN-FD controller and transceiver, and its USB virtual COM port can be switched into a mode that speaks SLCAN, the ASCII serial CAN protocol. That makes it a CAN-FD adapter for the standard tooling ecosystem rather than something that needs a bespoke SDK: python-can drives it through its stock `slcan` interface, and everything built on python-can follows. This application note switches a Pulsar into CAN-FD mode, works through the SLCAN protocol it then speaks, builds a second CAN-FD node on an Adafruit Feather M4 CAN Express so there is a real bus with two participants, and establishes what actually works: classic and FD frames in both directions, 64-byte payloads with bit-rate switching, DBC-driven decoding, and the CANopen, J1939 and ISO-TP stacks. Every output in this document is a real capture, and the reference node firmware, host utility and DBC are supplied.

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1

Introduction

The Binho Pulsar is a USB host adapter for I2C, SPI, UART and GPIO. It also carries an NXP MCAN controller and a TJA1044GT CAN-FD transceiver, and from firmware v4.4.0 its USB virtual COM port can be put into a mode that bridges that transceiver to the host using **SLCAN**, the ASCII serial CAN protocol originally from Lawicel and now spoken by a wide range of adapters and tools.

That last part is what makes this worth a document. The Pulsar's Python SDK has no CAN commands at all, and none are needed: in CAN-FD mode the device behaves as a conventional SLCAN adapter, so the existing CAN software ecosystem drives it unchanged.

Table 1. What CAN-FD adds to classic CAN

Feature	What it gives a design
64-byte payloads	Eight bytes becomes sixty-four, so a record that classic CAN has to fragment across frames and reassemble fits in one
Bit-rate switching	The arbitration phase stays at a rate every node can follow while the data phase runs faster, because only one node is driving by then
Larger DLC encoding	DLC values 9 to F select 12, 16, 20, 24, 32, 48 and 64 bytes, so payloads above 8 are addressed by a step table rather than a byte count
Stronger frame check	A CRC sized to the payload, with a stuff-bit count, rather than the single 15-bit polynomial classic CAN uses for every length
Unchanged physical layer	The same two wires, the same transceivers, the same 120 Ω termination
Coexistence	Classic and FD frames share a bus, and a frame is classic or FD per frame rather than per bus

Three properties of this setup determine how a host is written, and all three differ from the other adapters in this series.

Table 2. What differs from the other Binho host adapters

Property	Consequence for the host
CAN-FD is a CDC mode, not an SDK command group	The mode is selected over HID and stored in flash, then the device is a dedicated SLCAN bridge. While it is, the I2C, SPI, UART and GPIO managers do not run
The interface is a serial line protocol	Commands are ASCII terminated by carriage return, and the device answers <code>\r</code> for accepted and <code>\a</code> for rejected. That is diagnosable with a terminal, with no library in the way
The host is one node on a shared bus	Unlike a point-to-point bus, frames appear unbidden, need acknowledging by somebody, and arrive while the host is busy elsewhere. Sections 8.2 and 13 are both consequences of that

This note works through a Pulsar and a second CAN-FD node built for the purpose: switching the Pulsar into CAN-FD mode, the SLCAN protocol it speaks, building and bringing up the far-end node, proving classic and FD traffic in both directions, then driving the bus from python-can and the stacks built on it.

Nothing here requires a bespoke SDK. Every host-side step is either a line of ASCII on a serial port or a call into software that was already on the shelf.

1.1 Scope

By the end of this document a reader with the hardware in front of them will have switched a Pulsar into CAN-FD mode, confirmed the bridge answers SLCAN, built a second CAN-FD node and matched its bit timing to the adapter, exchanged classic and 64-byte FD frames with bit-rate switching in both directions, decoded live traffic through a DBC, captured and replayed a log, and driven the bus from the CANopen, J1939 and ISO-TP stacks.

The worked example pairs a Pulsar with an Adafruit Feather M4 CAN Express. Both are exercised on hardware and every output in this document is a real capture.

This note covers Windows-native host tooling. The `can-utils` and SocketCAN family, which is how the same tools are usually reached on Linux, is out of scope: on Windows it needs a USB passthrough layer and a Linux environment, and neither is required to use the adapter.

1.2 Applicable devices

CAN-FD mode is **Pulsar only**. The Binho Supernova's microcontroller has no MCAN peripheral, and its firmware rejects the mode. The host-side material applies to any SLCAN adapter; the node firmware applies to any board built on a SAM E51 with its CAN1 pins brought out.

1.3 Related documents

Table 3. Related documents

Document	Where
CDC CAN-FD (SLCAN) mode	Binho firmware documentation, <code>docs/CDC-CANFD-Mode.md</code> ; the authority on the bridge's command set and limits
Binho Pulsar documentation	<code>https://support.binho.io</code>
python-can	<code>https://python-can.readthedocs.io</code>
cantools	<code>https://cantools.readthedocs.io</code>
ACANFD_FeatherM4CAN	<code>https://github.com/pierremolinaro/acanfd-featherM4can</code> , the CAN-FD driver used for the node
CAN FD specification	Robert Bosch GmbH, <i>CAN with Flexible Data-Rate</i> , v1.0
ISO 11898-1	CAN data link layer, including the FD frame format

2 Required equipment and software

2.1 Hardware

Table 4. Required equipment

Item
Binho Pulsar, on firmware v4.4.0 or later
Adafruit Feather M4 CAN Express, or another CAN-FD node
Two-wire CAN link between the two, CANH to CANH and CANL to CANL
120 Ω termination
Two USB-C cables

2.2 Connections

Table 5. Signals used

Signal	Purpose
CANH	CAN bus, dominant-high line
CANL	CAN bus, dominant-low line
GND	Common return between the two boards

The Pulsar's CANH and CANL come from its onboard TJA1044GT; the Feather's come from the transceiver on that board. No third wire is needed, and neither board supplies the other.

NOTE CAN needs termination, and it needs a second node. A bus with one talker and no acknowledger does not half-work: the transmitter never sees an acknowledgement, retries the frame indefinitely, and its transmit queue backs up behind the first frame it ever sent. Section 14 lists what that looks like from each end, since the symptom points at the adapter rather than the bus.

2.3 Bus settings

Table 6. Bus settings used

Setting	Value	Set by
Arbitration bitrate	500 kbit/s	SLCAN <code>S6</code> , and <code>DataBitRateFactor</code> base on the node
Data-phase bitrate	2 Mbit/s	SLCAN <code>Y2</code> , and <code>DataBitRateFactor::x4</code> on the node
Termination	120 Ω	Hardware
Serial port rate	irrelevant	See below

The COM port's baud rate does not matter. The port is a USB CDC endpoint rather than a real UART, so the number is discarded; the CAN bitrate comes from the `S` and `Y` commands and nothing else.

2.4 Software

```
pip install python-can cantools
```

Python 3.12 with `python-can` and `cantools` covers everything in Sections 8 and 9. Section 10 adds `canopen`, `can-j1939` and `can-isotp`. Switching the CDC mode needs `hidapi`.

For the node firmware, the Arduino toolchain with the Adafruit SAMD core and one library:

```
arduino-cli core install adafruit:samd \
  --additional-urls https://adafruit.github.io/arduino-board-
  index/package_adafruit_index.json
arduino-cli lib install ACANFD_FeatherM4CAN
```

NOTE on Windows, install the core into the default Arduino location. The GCC toolchain reaches about 130 characters of path depth on its own, and a data directory placed somewhere deep pushes `cc1plus.exe` past the 260 character limit. The failure is `cannot execute 'cc1plus'`, which does not look like a path problem.

3 Switching the Pulsar into CAN-FD mode

CAN-FD is one of several functional modes for the USB virtual COM port. The mode is set over HID and stored in flash, so it survives a power cycle, and the firmware's own tool applies it:

```
python device_settings_cli.py --device pulsar show
```

```
Connected to Binho Pulsar
webusb_enabled : 1 (on)
cdc_enabled    : 1 (on)
cdc_mode       : 0 (uart_passthrough)
```

Mode 0 is the default, a transparent USB-to-UART bridge. That is worth knowing before anything else, because a Pulsar in the default mode presents a COM port that answers no SLCAN command and produces no output. It is not faulty and it is not the wrong port; it is bridging a UART.

```
python device_settings_cli.py --device pulsar set --cdc-mode canfd
```

```
Settings updated:
cdc_mode       : 4 (canfd)

Resetting device to persist settings to flash...
```

The reset is expected: the mode is applied at boot, so the tool restarts the device to make the setting take effect. The Pulsar then re-enumerates, and the COM port it comes back as is the SLCAN interface.

Two consequences follow from the mode being exclusive.

While the Pulsar is in CAN-FD mode the **HID protocol managers do not run**. I2C, SPI, UART and GPIO are unavailable until the mode is changed back; the device is a dedicated SLCAN bridge. Settings commands still work over HID, which is how the mode is changed back:

```
python device_settings_cli.py --device pulsar set --cdc-mode uart_passthrough
```

And because the setting is in flash, a Pulsar left in CAN-FD mode comes back in CAN-FD mode. If a unit appears to have lost its I2C and SPI, this is the first thing to check.

4 The SLCAN protocol

4.1 Command set

Commands are ASCII, one per line, terminated by a carriage return. The device answers `\r` (0x0D) when it accepts a command and `\a` (0x07, bell) when it does not. That makes the whole interface reachable from a terminal, which is the right place to start when something is not working.

Table 7. SLCAN commands

Command	Meaning	Notes
S0–S8	Select arbitration bitrate	Captured when the channel opens
Y1, Y2, Y5	Select CAN-FD data-phase bitrate	Captured when the channel opens
O	Open the channel, normal mode	
L	Open the channel, listen-only	Does not acknowledge; see Section 13
C	Close the channel	Transceiver goes to standby
t / T	Transmit classic frame, standard / extended ID	
d / D	Transmit FD frame without bit-rate switching	
b / B	Transmit FD frame with bit-rate switching	
V, N, F	Version, serial number, status flags	Fixed constants in this firmware
s	Custom bit timing	Accepted and ignored; use S

Confirming the bridge answers, before involving any library:

```
python canfd_slcan.py probe --port COM12 --bitrate 500000 --data-bitrate 2000000
```

```
V -> b'V0101\r'    ok    version
N -> b'NFFFF\r'    ok    serial number
F -> b'F00\r'      ok    status flags
S6 -> b'\r'        ok    nominal 500000
Y2 -> b'\r'        ok    data phase 2000000
Q -> b'\x07'       ok    an unsupported command should bell
```

The last line matters as much as the others. A device that answered everything identically would prove nothing; one that bells an unknown command is parsing.

V, N and F return constants rather than live values, so they prove the bridge is listening, not which device it is or what state the bus is in.

4.2 Frame format

A transmit frame is one string:

```
<letter><identifier><dlc><data bytes>
```

The letter carries three facts at once. Whether the frame is classic (**t**) or FD (**d**, **b**); whether the data phase switches rate, which is **b** and **B** but not **d** and **D**; and whether the identifier is standard, which is lowercase, or extended, which is uppercase. The identifier is three hex digits for standard and eight for extended, the DLC is one hex digit, and the data follows as byte pairs.

Received frames arrive in the same shape, unsolicited, once the channel is open.

t1238DEADBEEF00112233	classic, std 0x123, 8 bytes
b200F0102...	FD with BRS, std 0x200, DLC F = 64 bytes

4.3 Bitrates and the DLC mapping

Table 8. DLC to payload length

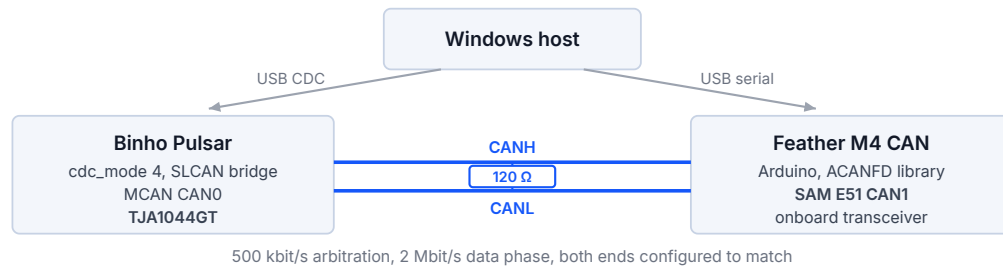
DLC	0-8	9	A	B	C	D	E	F
Bytes	0-8	12	16	20	24	32	48	64

Above 8 bytes, payload lengths come from that step table rather than being free. A 20-byte payload is DLC **B**; a 13-byte payload does not exist and has to be padded to 16. The supplied utility pads automatically, which is a decision worth making explicit somewhere rather than leaving a caller to wonder why their 13 bytes became 16.

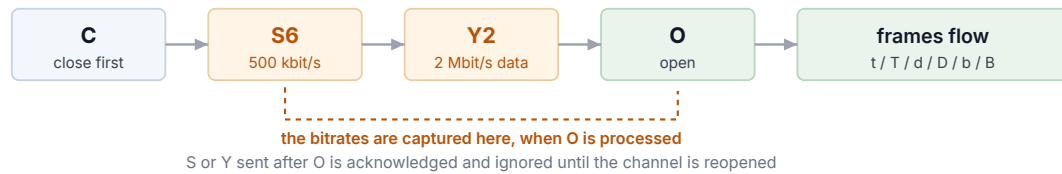
Bitrates are captured when the channel opens. **Send s and y before o**. Setting them afterwards is accepted and acknowledged and has no effect until the channel is closed and reopened, which is the sort of failure that looks like a bit-timing problem rather than an ordering one.

The bus, and the order the channel has to be opened in

TWO NODES, ONE BUS



OPENING THE CHANNEL, IN THIS ORDER



Every reply is a single byte: carriage return for accepted, bell (0x07) for rejected

Figure 1. The bus, and the order the channel has to be opened in.

5

The far-end node

A CAN bus needs a second participant, both to acknowledge frames and to have anything worth looking at. The node used here is an Adafruit Feather M4 CAN Express, which pairs a SAM E51 with a CAN-FD transceiver, programmed in Arduino C++ with the

`ACANFD_FeatherM4CAN` library.

NOTE CircuitPython's `canio` module was measured on this board and is **classic CAN only**: `Message` accepts at most 8 bytes, and the constructor rejects `fd`, `can_fd` and `data_bitrate`. The MCAN peripheral itself does FD, and a `canio` loopback confirms the controller works, but FD is not exposed. A CAN-FD node on this board therefore has to be built in C++.

5.1

Which CAN module, and the two pins that decide whether it works

The SAM E51 has two CAN modules and the board wires **CAN1** to the onboard transceiver. CAN1 is the only one whose CANH and CANL reach the header; CAN0 exists, on D12 and D13, with nothing behind it.

Two pins decide whether a correctly configured node ever drives the bus. The transceiver has a standby input that must be driven low to make it active, and a boost converter enable that must be driven high. Left alone, both leave a node that configures without error, reports successful transmissions, and puts nothing on the wire.

The library handles both inside `beginFD` for CAN1, driving PB12 low and PB13 high. That is worth knowing rather than assuming: on a board where it is not handled, this is the first thing to check.

5.2 Matching the bit timing

The node expresses its data-phase rate as a **multiple** of the arbitration rate, not as an absolute figure:

```
ACANFD_FeatherM4CAN_Settings settings(
    ACANFD_FeatherM4CAN_Settings::CLOCK_48MHz, 500 * 1000, DataBitRateFactor::x4);
settings.mModuleMode = ACANFD_FeatherM4CAN_Settings::NORMAL_FD;
const uint32_t errorCode = can1.beginFD(settings);
```

500 kbit/s with a factor of four is 2 Mbit/s, which is SLCAN `S6` then `Y2`. Both ends have to agree before either opens its channel.

`beginFD` returns non-zero if it cannot find bit timing for the requested combination, and the node reports that rather than continuing, because a node that silently ran at the wrong rate would be harder to diagnose than one that refused.

5.3 Resending a received frame

The one non-obvious defect worth documenting. `CANFDMessage` has an `idx` field that belongs to the driver, and on a received frame it holds the index the frame arrived under. Copying a received frame to echo it therefore carries a non-zero `idx`, which the transmit path reads as *use dedicated transmit buffer number idx*, a buffer that does not exist:

```
CANFDMessage reply = frame; // carries frame.idx
reply.id = RESPONSE_ID;
reply.idx = 0; // without this, status 2 and nothing on the bus
```

The symptom is a transmit status of 2, `kTransmitBufferIndexTooLarge`, and no frame. Zero means *use the transmit FIFO*, which is what an echo wants.

6 First traffic

With both ends at matching rates, the node's own console shows it configuring and transmitting:

```
=== Feather M4 CAN :: CAN-FD test node ===
arbitration 500000 bit/s, data x4 = 2000000 bit/s (SLCAN: S6 then Y2)
CAN1 configured, transceiver active
diagnostic: 0x100 heartbeat, 0x200 ramp, 0x123->0x321 echo
device:     0x110 environment, 0x210 trace, 0x600->0x601 cmd
```

And from the host, opening the channel and listening:

```
python canfd_slcan.py listen --port COM12 --bitrate 500000 --data-bitrate 2000000
```

```
channel open (normal), 500000 nominal, 2000000 data; collecting for 4 s
id=0x100 classic len=8   x8
id=0x110 classic len=8   x41
id=0x200 fd+brs  len=64  x4
id=0x210 fd+brs  len=48  x20
73 frame string(s), 73 decoded, 4 distinct
```

The counts are worth checking against the periods in Section 7, because they are the cheapest confirmation that nothing is being dropped: over four seconds, `0x100` at 500 ms gives 8, `0x110` at 100 ms gives 41, `0x200` at 1 s gives 4, and `0x210` at 200 ms gives 20. A count well below its period implies loss; one that matches means the whole catalogue is arriving.

Two of those are the reason for doing any of this. `0x200` is a 64-byte frame with bit-rate switching, and `0x210` is a 48-byte one; neither can be received by a classic-CAN host at all. A tool that shows them is genuinely doing FD rather than reporting that it does.

The reverse direction, and the FD round trip:

```
python canfd_slcan.py roundtrip --port COM12 --bitrate 500000 --data-bitrate 2000000
```

```
--- classic ---
drained 9 buffered frame(s) first
reply id=0x321 classic dlc=8 len=8
payload identical: True

--- CAN-FD, 64 bytes, BRS ---
drained 0 buffered frame(s) first
reply id=0x321 fd+brs dlc=64 len=64
payload identical: True
```

The FD request came back as an FD reply with bit-rate switching preserved and the payload byte-identical. That is the assertion a transmit test cannot make: it proves the far end received what was sent, and that nothing downgraded the frame on the way through.

7 The demo node's message catalogue

The node is deliberately two things at once, and the split is worth keeping in any test node.

The **diagnostic layer** exists to prove the bus works, and does as little as possible so that when it fails the cause is narrow.

Table 9. Diagnostic messages

ID	Frame	Rate	Contents
0x100	classic, 8 bytes	500 ms	Sequence number and receive counters
0x200	FD with BRS, 64 bytes	1 s	A byte ramp
0x123 → 0x321	follows the request	on demand	Echo, preserving frame type and BRS

The **device layer** sits on top and exists so a host has something worth decoding. None of it is needed to diagnose the bus.

Table 10. Simulated device messages

ID	Frame	Rate	Contents
0x110	classic, 8 bytes	100 ms, changeable	Temperature, humidity, pressure, flags, sequence
0x210	FD with BRS, 48 bytes	200 ms	A 16-sample waveform trace with a header
0x600 → 0x601	classic, 8 bytes	on demand	INFO, COUNTERS, SET_RATE

0x210 is the message that argues *for* CAN-FD rather than merely exercising it. Sixteen 16-bit samples behind a 12-byte header is 44 bytes in one frame. The same trace over classic CAN is six frames plus a reassembly scheme, and those six frames interleave with everything else on the bus, so the receiver also needs to handle them arriving out of order or incomplete.

Decoded from the wire:

```
python canfd_slcan.py monitor --port COM12 --bitrate 500000 --data-bitrate 2000000
```

```
0x100 heartbeat seq=11024 rx=10 echoes=0
0x110 environment 19.7 C 49.1 %RH 1012.7 hPa flags=0x01 seq=212
0x200 fd ramp 64 bytes, first=0x88
0x210 trace seq=27560 uptime=5515031 ms 16 samples peak=7998 [7331, 5548, 2921,
-151, -3200, -5762, ...]
```

The command endpoint answers on 0x601, echoing the command byte in the first position so a reply matches its request without needing a transaction identifier:

```
python canfd_slcan.py command info --port COM12 --bitrate 500000 --data-bitrate 2000000
```

```
TX t600101 (info)
RX 0x601 cmd INFO id=BIN fw=1.0 features=0x07 trace_samples=16
```

`SET_RATE` is worth a word because it demonstrates something a read-only catalogue cannot. Asking for 250 ms:

```
TX t600303FA00 (set-rate)
RX 0x601 cmd SET_RATE period=250 ms, accepted
```

Listening again shows `0x110` at 16 frames in four seconds rather than 41, while every other identifier keeps its count, so the command changed the device's behaviour rather than only being acknowledged:

```
id=0x100 classic len=8 x8
id=0x110 classic len=8 x16
id=0x200 fd+brs len=64 x4
id=0x210 fd+brs len=48 x20
```

An out-of-range request is **clamped rather than rejected**, and the reply carries the value that actually took effect. Asking for 5 ms, below the node's 10 ms floor:

```
TX t6003030500 (set-rate)
RX 0x601 cmd SET_RATE period=10 ms, accepted
```

The reply, not the request, is the authority on the period the device is running at. A caller that assumes otherwise is right until it asks for something outside the range.

All multi-byte fields are **little-endian**. CAN itself imposes no byte order, so this is a choice, and one that has to be written down or the two ends quietly disagree.

8 Driving the bus from python-can

The bridge is an ordinary SLCAN adapter to python-can, through its stock interface and with no Binho-specific code:

```
import can

bus = can.Bus(interface="slcan", channel="COM12", bitrate=500_000)
bus.set_bitrate(500_000, 2_000_000) # nominal, then FD data phase

bus.send(can.Message(arbitration_id=0x123, is_extended_id=False,
                    data=bytes(range(64)), is_fd=True, bitrate_switch=True))
print(bus.recv(timeout=1.0))
bus.shutdown()
```

8.1 Why `set_bitrate` works, and a constructor alone does not

The FD data-phase rate cannot be passed to the constructor. `set_bitrate` is the route, and it works because of what it does internally: it closes the channel, writes `S` and `Y`, and reopens. That is exactly the ordering Section 4.3 requires. Setting the rates on an already-open channel would be accepted and ignored.

Table 11. python-can bitrate mapping

Asked for	Sent	Bus runs at
500 000	S6	500 kbit/s
1 000 000	S8	1 Mbit/s
750 000	S7	800 kbit/s
data 2 000 000	Y2	2 Mbit/s
data 5 000 000	Y5	5 Mbit/s

The third row is a trap. python-can's table maps 750 000 to `S7`, and this firmware's `S7` is 800 kbit/s. Asking for 750 kbit/s puts the bus at 800 kbit/s with no warning from either side. The backend also offers only 2 and 5 Mbit/s for the data phase, so `Y1` is reachable from the raw protocol but not through that interface.

8.2 The backlog, and why a request/response test needs draining

This one costs real time. The node transmits continuously, and the bridge keeps buffering while the host spends its two-second port settle and its channel close-and-reopen. By the time a request goes out there is a queue of unrelated frames ahead of its reply.

A loop that sends and then reads the next few frames reads *history*. The reply is there, behind the backlog, and a working node looks like it never answered. Draining first is what makes the measurement mean anything:

```
--- classic request/response ---
drained 42 buffered frame(s) first
reply id=0x321 classic dlc=8 len=8 data=DEADBEEF00010203
```

Forty-two frames of history in that instance. Without the drain, the same test reported no reply at all from a node that had answered correctly.

8.3 Logging and replay

python-can installs command-line tools that cover the capture and replay workflow:

```
python -m can.logger -i slcan -c COM12 -b 500000 --fd --data-bitrate 2000000 -f
capture.asc
python -m can.player -i slcan -c COM12 -b 500000 --fd --data-bitrate 2000000 capture.asc
```

The log is a Vector ASC file with correct FD records, the `f 64` being DLC F and its byte count:

```
0.000000 1 100          Rx  d 8 00 00 07 6E 00 07 00 07
0.000000 CANFD 1 Rx      200  1 0 f 64 B7 B8 B9 BA BB BC ...
```

Replaying it put the frames back on the wire, and the node received them: 17 copies of `0x100` and 13 of `0x200`.

NOTE every timestamp in that capture reads `0.000000`. The firmware does not implement the SLCAN timestamp commands (`Z0/Z1`), so there is nothing for python-can to record. The log is structurally valid and its FD records are correct, but it carries no timing information. Anything that needs inter-frame timing has to take it from the host instead.

9 Decoding with a DBC

A DBC turns raw bytes into named, scaled signals, and it is the most common CAN workflow there is. `cantools` reads one and decodes live traffic:

```
import can, cantools

db = cantools.database.load_file("binho_canfd_demo.dbc")
bus = can.Bus(interface="slcan", channel="COM12", bitrate=500_000)
bus.set_bitrate(500_000, 2_000_000)

message = bus.recv(timeout=1.0)
print(db.decode_message(message.arbitration_id, message.data))
```

```
0x100 Heartbeat      Seq=7787, RxCount=4, EchoCount=0
0x110 Environment    Temperature=20.3, Humidity=42.4, Pressure=1014.2, Flags=1,
EnvSeq=159
0x200 FdRamp          FirstByte=53
0x210 Telemetry       TraceSeq=19469, UptimeMs=3896831, SampleCount=16, Reserved=0,
Sample00=-3434, ...
```

The supplied DBC describes all seven messages and 35 signals. It is generated from a script rather than hand-written, for two reasons worth repeating: the trace has sixteen signals whose bit offsets invite an off-by-one, and a DBC with a one-bit slip decodes to plausible nonsense rather than failing.

NOTE a DBC must mark its FD messages, or a reader treats a 48- or 64-byte message as a malformed classic frame. The attribute is `VFrameFormat`, set to `StandardCAN_FD`. `cantools` reads it but does not write it, so a DBC produced by dumping a database loses the flag; the supplied generator appends it and then reloads the file to confirm it survived.

The `cantools` command line covers the rest of the workflow without any code:

Table 12. cantools subcommands

Command	What it does
<code>dump</code>	Prints each message with a bit-layout diagram
<code>decode</code>	Decodes candump-format text through the DBC
<code>monitor</code>	Live decoded view, curses based
<code>plot</code>	Plots decoded signals over time
<code>convert</code>	Between DBC, KCD, SYM, ARXML
<code>generate_c_source</code>	Emits C encoders and decoders for the embedded side

```
python -m cantools decode binho_canfd_demo.dbc < candump.log
```

```
can0 210 [48] 0E 4C 00 00 C7 76 3B 00 10 00 00 00 03 F4 ... ::
Telemetry(
    TraceSeq: 19470,
    UptimeMs: 3897031 ms,
    SampleCount: 16,
    Sample00: -3069,
    Sample01: -8,
    ...
)
```

NOTE `decode` and `plot` consume **candump** text, while `can.logger` writes **ASC**. Those two formats do not interoperate directly, so a capture intended for `cantools` has to be written in candump format. This is a seam in the tooling rather than a limitation of the adapter.

10 Higher-level stacks

Because the bridge is an ordinary SLCAN adapter, the protocol stacks built on python-can work over it unchanged. Each of the following was checked by asking the stack to transmit and confirming at the *node* that the frame reached the wire, rather than by observing that the library accepted the call.

Table 13. Stacks verified over the bridge

Stack	What it sent	Seen at the node
<code>canopen</code>	NMT reset, the broadcast a CANopen master opens with	<code>0x000</code>
<code>can-j1939</code>	Address claim, PGN <code>0xEE00</code> carrying the 8-byte NAME	<code>0x18EEFF80</code> , extended
<code>can-isotp</code>	A 60-byte ISO-TP single frame over CAN-FD	<code>0x700</code>

```
import canopen
network = canopen.Network()
network.connect(interface="slcan", channel="COM12", bitrate=500_000)
network.nmt.state = "RESET"
network.disconnect()
```

The ISO-TP case is the interesting one, and it is another argument for FD. Configured with a 64-byte transmit length, ISO-TP carries a payload up to 62 bytes in a **single frame**, which needs no flow control and therefore no cooperating peer to demonstrate:

```
import can, isotp
bus = can.Bus(interface="slcan", channel="COM12", bitrate=500_000)
bus.set_bitrate(500_000, 2_000_000)
stack = isotp.CanStack(
    bus=bus,
    address=isotp.Address(isotp.AddressingMode.Normal_11bits, txid=0x700, rxid=0x701),
    params={"tx_data_length": 64, "can_fd": True, "bitrate_switch": True})
stack.start()
stack.send(bytes(range(60)))
```

The same 60 bytes over classic CAN is a first frame, eight consecutive frames and a flow-control handshake. That transport is what UDS runs on, so `udsoncan` follows the same path; a full diagnostic session needs a peer that implements an ISO-TP server, which the demo node deliberately does not.

11

Measured results

11.1

Test configuration

Table 14. Test configuration

Item	Value
Adapter	Binho Pulsar, hardware rev C, firmware 4.5.0, <code>cdc_mode</code> 4
Node	Adafruit Feather M4 CAN Express, SAM E51, <code>ACANFD_FeatherM4CAN</code> 2.0.0
Node firmware size	23,484 bytes, 4% of flash
Bus	500 kbit/s arbitration, 2 Mbit/s data phase, 120 Ω terminated
Host	Windows 11, Python 3.12, python-can 4.6.1, cantools 43.0.2

11.2 What the bridge implements

Table 15. Verified behaviour

Feature	Result
Classic frames, standard ID	Yes, both directions
CAN-FD frames, up to 64 bytes	Yes, both directions, payload verified byte-identical
Bit-rate switching	Yes, per frame, and preserved through an echo
Extended identifiers	Yes; observed on the J1939 address claim, <code>0x18EEFF80</code>
Arbitration bitrates	<code>S0</code> – <code>S8</code>
Data-phase bitrates	<code>Y1</code> , <code>Y2</code> , <code>Y5</code>
Listen-only mode	Yes, <code>L</code> ; see the caution in Section 13
Unknown command handling	Bell, <code>0x07</code>
Receive timestamps	Not implemented; every logged timestamp is zero
Error and bus-state reporting	Not implemented; <code>F</code> returns a constant
Remote transmission requests	Not supported
Host-side acceptance filtering	Not implemented; all identifiers are received

11.3 Host software verified

Table 16. Host software driven over the bridge

Software	Verified
python-can 4.6.1, <code>slcan</code>	Classic and FD transmit and receive, FD round trip
<code>can.logger</code>	ASC capture with correct FD records
<code>can.player</code>	Replay onto the bus, received at the node
cantools 43.0.2	DBC decode of live frames; <code>dump</code> , <code>decode</code>
canopen 2.4.1	NMT broadcast on the bus
can-j1939 2.0.12	Address claim on the bus
can-isotp 2.0.7	60-byte single frame over FD
udsoncan 1.26.1	Installed; rides on can-isotp, needs an ISO-TP peer
canmatrix 1.2	Installed; database conversion, no bus involved

12 The reference material

Table 17. What is supplied

File	Purpose
<code>assets/canfd_node/canfd_node.ino</code>	The CAN-FD node firmware
<code>assets/tools/canfd_slcan.py</code>	Host utility, eight subcommands
<code>assets/tools/device_settings_cli.py</code>	Switches the Pulsar's CDC mode
<code>assets/dbc/binho_canfd_demo.dbc</code>	DBC for the node's seven messages
<code>assets/dbc/generate_dbc.py</code>	Generates and self-checks that DBC

The utility keeps two layers apart on purpose.

`probe`, `listen`, `send`, `monitor` and `command` speak SLCAN over the serial port with no CAN library involved. That is the layer where a problem is diagnosable, because the exact ASCII sent and the exact `\r` or `\a` returned are both visible.

`roundtrip` goes through python-can's stock interface instead, which is how a reader will actually use the adapter. Running both against the same hardware localises a fault: if the raw layer works and the library layer does not, the fault is in how the library is being driven.

Table 18. Utility subcommands

Command	What it does
<code>mode</code>	How to switch the CDC mode, and what that costs
<code>probe</code>	Check the bridge answers SLCAN
<code>rates</code>	The bitrate tables and the DLC mapping
<code>listen</code>	Decode frames off the bus, by identifier
<code>send</code>	Transmit one frame, classic or FD, with optional BRS
<code>monitor</code>	Decode the demo node's catalogue into engineering units
<code>command</code>	Send <code>INFO</code> , <code>COUNTERS</code> or <code>SET_RATE</code> and decode the reply
<code>roundtrip</code>	Request and response through python-can, classic and FD

13 Practical notes

Send `S` and `Y` before `O`. Bitrates are captured when the channel opens. Setting them afterwards is accepted, acknowledged, and ineffective until the channel is closed and reopened.

Drain before a request/response measurement. The bridge buffers bus traffic while the host is opening the port and cycling the channel, so a reply sits behind a backlog. Reading the next few frames after sending reads history.

Listen-only mode cannot be the only other node. `L` opens a channel that never acknowledges. On a two-node bus that is fatal to the peer: nothing acknowledges its frames, the controller retries them indefinitely, and it never advances past the first frame it sent. The symptom is thousands of copies of one message and nothing else. Use `L` only where a third node acknowledges.

Clear `idx` when resending a received frame. On the node side, a copied receive descriptor carries the driver's own index and the transmit path reads it as a dedicated buffer number.

Parse received frame strings defensively. A read window routinely opens mid-frame, so the first string out of the buffer is often a tail with no leading letter or an odd number of hex digits. That is normal, and a decoder that raises on it will stop a monitor that was working.

A Pulsar in CAN-FD mode has no I2C, SPI, UART or GPIO, and the setting persists across power cycles. If those interfaces appear to have vanished, check `cdc_mode` first.

Padding is not optional above 8 bytes. FD lengths come from a step table, so a 13-byte payload has to be padded to 16.

14

Troubleshooting

Table 19. Troubleshooting

Symptom	Likely cause
The COM port answers nothing, no banner, no bell	The Pulsar is in <code>uart_passthrough</code> mode; it is bridging a UART, not speaking SLCAN
Every command returns a bell	Malformed command, or a transmit attempted while the channel is closed or listen-only
Commands accepted but no frames ever arrive	Channel not opened with <code>0</code> , bitrate mismatch between the ends, missing termination, or CANH and CANL swapped
Thousands of copies of one identifier, nothing else	The adapter was opened with <code>L</code> ; the peer's frames are unacknowledged and being retried forever
Node reports transmit status 2	A received frame was resent without clearing <code>idx</code>
Node reports transmit status 3	Its queue is full because nothing is acknowledging: peer channel closed, or termination missing
Bitrate change appears ignored	<code>S</code> or <code>Y</code> sent after <code>0</code> ; close and reopen
Asked for 750 kbit/s, bus runs at 800	python-can maps 750 000 to <code>S7</code> , which is 800 kbit/s in this firmware
Request/response reports no reply, but the node logged one	The reply was behind the receive backlog; drain before sending
Logged timestamps are all zero	The firmware does not implement <code>Z0</code> / <code>Z1</code> ; take timing from the host
A DBC decodes 48- or 64-byte messages as malformed	The DBC is missing <code>VFrameFormat</code> on those messages
<code>cannot execute 'cc1plus'</code> when building the node	Windows path length; install the Arduino core at its default location
The node configures but never drives the bus	Transceiver standby not asserted, or its boost converter not enabled

15

Acronyms

Table 20. Acronyms

Term	Meaning
BRS	Bit-rate switch
CAN	Controller Area Network
CAN-FD	CAN with Flexible Data-rate
CDC	Communications Device Class, the USB serial-port class
DBC	Vector database format for CAN networks
DLC	Data length code
ECU	Electronic control unit
FD	Flexible Data-rate
HID	Human Interface Device, the USB class the SDK uses
ISO-TP	ISO 15765-2 transport protocol
MCAN	The Bosch M_CAN controller licensed into many microcontrollers
NMT	Network management, a CANopen service
PGN	Parameter group number, a J1939 identifier
RTR	Remote transmission request
SLCAN	Serial line CAN, the ASCII adapter protocol
UDS	Unified Diagnostic Services, ISO 14229

16

Note about the source code in the document

Example code shown in this document and supplied in the accompanying archive is provided for evaluation and reference. It is released under the MIT license, the text of which is included in the archive.

`device_settings_cli.py` is Binho's own firmware tool, included so the mode switch in Section 3 can be reproduced without a separate download. The node firmware depends on the `ACANFD_FeatherM4CAN` library by Pierre Molinaro, which is installed from the Arduino library manager and is not redistributed here.

Table 21. Contents of the assets archive

File	Description
<code>AN0012.md</code>	Markdown source of this document
<code>assets/canfd_node/canfd_node.ino</code>	CAN-FD node firmware for the Feather M4 CAN Express
<code>assets/tools/canfd_slcan.py</code>	Host utility for the SLCAN bridge
<code>assets/tools/device_settings_cli.py</code>	CDC mode switching over HID
<code>assets/dbc/binho_canfd_demo.dbc</code>	DBC describing the node's messages
<code>assets/dbc/generate_dbc.py</code>	Generator for that DBC
<code>assets/LICENSE</code>	MIT license covering the example code

17

Revision history**Table 22.** Revision history

Revision	Date	Description
0.1	9 September 2026	Draft for internal review. Written as AN0008 and renumbered to AN0012 before review; no change to any measurement. Every result was taken on a Pulsar at firmware 4.5.0 against a purpose-built CAN-FD node, with the host tooling limited to what runs natively on Windows.

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